

S05-02 - The Ritual Begins

Player text

The Custodian lets out a shrill cry. "The Keystone has finally responded! Surround me, the ritual must begin or I'll lose the pathway! Hurry!" Her glow swells, her eyes roll back, and the carriage lifts a foot off the ground. From the woods comes a chorus of unearthly screeches. The ground rumbles. Rusty swords break the surface as dead things claw their way up. In the distance, two shapes drift toward you, screeching, wrong. Hold the line until she's done.

Public objective

Begin the defense and understand the countdown.

GM goal

Start the ritual, show the first threats, and put the countdown die on the table.

GM notes

- Market Correction is available as a GM pressure valve, not player-facing terminology.

GM script

Say: "d8, starting at 8. Defeat an enemy or remove a real pressure, it ticks down one. She gets hit or exposed, it ticks up one. At zero, the ritual is done and you win. The math is simple; staying alive is not."

State controls

- ritual_prep Ritual Prep select unready ready
- keystone_understanding Keystone Understanding select surface deep
- protected_whom Protected Whom select unresolved custodian party hush shared
- strixwolf_disposition Strixwolf Disposition select unresolved calm hostile killed
- strixwolf_outcome Strixwolf Outcome select unresolved calmed helped avoided attacked killed
- strixwolf_trust Strixwolf Trust number 3
- strixwolf_blood_debt Strixwolf Blood Debt checkbox
- bramble_outcome Bramble Outcome select unresolved killed captured spared negotiated escaped let_cargo
- bramble_truth_learned Bramble Truth Learned checkbox
- package_status Package Status select held lost
- hush_trust Hush Trust select low neutral high
- custodian_route Custodian Route select unknown safe dangerous
- ward_awareness Ward Awareness select none seed aware
- festival_boon Festival Boon select none charm favor market_find goodwill

- custodian_trust Custodian Trust select low neutral high
- ward_stability Ward Stability select fragile stable
- hush_clues Hush Clues select none custodian_route ward_seed corporate_seam farm_seed
market_rumor multiple
- ritual_countdown Ritual Countdown number 10 8
- ritual_outcome Ritual Outcome select unresolved clean costly pyrrhic
- custodian_fate Custodian Fate select unresolved well drained dying

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